

OUR STORY

It began with one scientist looking closer.



Dr. Elaine Ingham at the microscope.

The Soil Food Web Foundation was established in October 2025 to carry forward the life's work of Dr. Elaine Ingham, the pioneering scientist whose research transformed our understanding of soil biology and its central role in food production, ecosystem health, and planetary regeneration.

She passed away in February 2026, and the work she started continues through the Foundation, the school that is a part of it, and Soil Food Web practitioners in more than 132 countries, who are helping to restore the world's soils.

From the mid-1980s to the mid-1990s, Dr. Ingham was a Faculty Member in Forest Science and Botany and Plant Pathology at Oregon State University. From 1996 onward, Dr. Ingham developed new methods of rapidly assessing soil and foliage-related organisms and researched how soil and foliar biology changes with different management practices. She served as the first President of the Soil Ecology Society, and co-authored the USDA's Soil Biology Primer. From 2011 to 2014, Dr. Ingham served as the Chief Scientist for the Rodale Institute in Pennsylvania before founding the Soil Food Web School in 2019. That school has grown into the nonprofit Soil Food Web Foundation.



Her published record, in full, on our site:
sfw.one/publications



Watch a free webinar

A live hour with an instructor or a practitioner, every month. The easiest first step.

sfw.one/brochure-webinar

RESEARCH

The science is open, and anyone can test it.



Soil samples beside the microscope.

Forty-five years of soil biology research, practiced by graduates in more than 132 countries on six continents.

What the biology does when it is intact



**NUTRIENT
CYCLING**



**SOIL
STRUCTURE**



**WEED
PRESSURE**



**PESTS AND
DISEASE**



Testate amoeba, 40x objective. Photograph: Joy Kaluf. A count names what is there: bacteria, fungi, protozoa, nematodes and microarthropods.

What we test before we recommend



Measurable. Every recommendation starts with a count, not a guess.



Diagnostic first. We look at your soil before we suggest anything.



Compatible. No need to tear up what you have.

Each mechanism we teach is established soil biology. How much of any one benefit a field sees depends on climate, crop, starting condition and management. We publish results by site, with the person and the year, and say what one site cannot prove.

Her publications and the wider research, item by item:
sfw.one/publications

PRACTICE

Growers are already doing this, at every scale.



Agroecology plots at Rancho Cacachilas.

The biology is universal; the practice is local. Every result we publish names the grower who got it and the year they did.

Nick Padwick farms four thousand acres in Norfolk, England. Roberto Silva works a hundred and forty in Piura, Peru. Jenn Sirp grows on a quarter acre in California. They film the work themselves and publish what changed, so nobody has to take our word for it.

The scale runs from that quarter acre to ten thousand acres of corn and soy in Illinois, and a public park on Governors Island in New York. The steps are the same at every size: look at the biology under a microscope, add what is missing, and measure again.

We partner with growers to trial the approach where they farm, and to document what happens when they do.



Find a trained professional near you

Consultants and lab technicians who finished the assessed programs are listed in our own directory.



Watch the case studies

Growers filming their own soil, crop by crop and climate by climate. Start with one that looks like yours.

sfw.one/brochure-casestudies